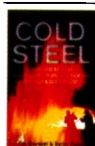


STEELING THE WORLD

The thrilling saga of how a combative Mittal acquired Arcelor ingot by ingot to become the world's largest steel maker



COLD STEEL: LAKSHMI MITTAL AND THE MULTI-BILLION-DOLLAR BATTLE FOR A GLOBAL EMPIRE

by TIM BOUQUET, BYRON OUSEY
Little, Brown

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■ By Shankkar Aiyar

They call it the defining moment. Sometimes an encounter or an episode often defines a person better than a biography would. Tim Bouquet and Byron Ousey's book on the battle for Arcelor defines the methods and the magnitude of one man's dreams, his tenacity at war and his success better than most biographies. Lakshmi Niwas Mittal will most definitely have an authorised biography in mind, but will perhaps time it for the next big event. *Cold Steel* bridges the gap and gives you a glimpse of what it takes to be the sultan of steel.

Mittal first spoke about his vision for the steel industry in 1998 at a world steel producers' meet. He said "Steel will have to consolidate like oil did into seven sisters." Not many took Mittal—who then produced just about 30 million tonnes of the global steel output of over 1,100 million tonnes—seriously. To the Anglo-Saxon world he was but a parvenu. But by 2006, all that had changed as he proved the established entrepreneurial world wrong, acquiring, succeeding and climbing the ladder to emerge as the world's largest steel maker, the new Carnegie of steel.

Cold Steel is a racy story of the takeover that takes you on a guided tour of the world of high finance, politics and business. Set in the context of the battle with Arcelor for Ukrainian company Kryvorizstal, the book, racing across 323 pages, establishes the background of what was perhaps the blood-



iest takeover battle in corporate history. It may sound like a book on mergers and acquisitions for students at Wharton, but it is also a thriller, a howdunnit on the acquisition of Arcelor. The clash of cultural identities, economic nationalism, nay patriotism, the raw face of ambition—it's all there.

It is a first-of-its-kind narrative on the intricacies of cross-border acquisitions, the geopolitics and of course, the politico-business nexus that comes into play. It is the saga of how for six months Mittal blended combativeness, co-

option and cooperation, literally acquiring Arcelor ingot by ingot. His conversations with Arcelor CEO Guy Dollé, the negotiations with the Luxembourg government, the use of diplomacy, the cloak-and-daggers method and the pure mercantile logic make it seem more like a Ludlum thriller than a book on a battle for a company.

The most exciting sections, interestingly, are not so much about the numbers but about grandmaster-like moves and counter-moves, and the speed with which Lakshmi and Aditya